Scrolling Past Democracy: A Look Into the Uses and Gratifications Theory and its Effects on Modern News Consumption Habits

Zoe Wilson

Department of Communication

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Dr. Dan Lane

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Introduction

The previous memo in the series of “Scrolling Past Democracy” discussed the general overview of the problem that modern day journalists are facing in connecting with today’s youth. With the recent switch into relying primarily on short-form content to stay informed, America’s younger generations have exhibited extreme trends in fake news sharing and misinformation, leading to potential issues such as increased polarization and decreased political mobility. This memo will provide a lens into the specific theory which motivates these trends to continue spreading through today’s youth. The theory which will be discussed is the Uses and Gratifications Theory of Communication. To our potential funders, it is with great hope that this analysis will provide deeper insight into these ongoing issues in order to ease your decision into helping further this endeavor.

Theory Overview - Causes

Uses and Gratifications Theory & Misinformation

The theory that can be used to explain the phenomenon of the younger generation’s habits of fake news sharing is the Uses and Gratifications Theory of Communication. In simple terms, the Uses and Gratifications Theory refers to the idea that humans are not passive consumers of media, but rather intentionally consume media sources fueled by the expected gratification, such as entertainment or social connection, they expect to receive from it (Ng & Zhao, 2020). While trends among older generations show that news consumption was primarily driven by information seeking behaviors, empirical evidence suggests that Generation Z’s media habits are motivated by something else, and that is social utility (Valenzuela et. al, 2016). Rather than seeking news to expand knowledge, young people instead see it as an opportunity to connect with peers through sharing and interacting with headlines on their feed as a means of self-

expression. Unfortunately, a boost in social status as gratification to consume news has not necessarily had positive effects on Generation Z's news habits. Studies have shown that the use of news as a social network, rather than an information outlet, has been directly linked to the sharing of fake news and misinformation. One study connected the uses and gratifications theory to the rise in "sensational news" consumption among youth, ultimately concluding that headlines which contained alarming and exaggerated language received significantly more likes and shares across social media platforms, even when the actual content of the article did not necessarily match (Ng & Zhao, 2020).

As Gen Z tends to share and consume news with the inner motivation to receive social validation, one may be inclined to share untrue and shocking news stories as a way to attract peers into discussion, bringing more attention to misinformation through reposting it to their feed. This especially becomes an issue when considering the recent trends of Gen Z's "news-finds-me" mindset, in which much of today's youth has put their trust into their curated social feed, rather than empirically seeking out information themselves. These factors have the potential to lead into a vicious cycle of viewing, interacting with, and resharing fake news content to others for the sake of social validation, leading to the further spread of misinformation.

Theory Overview - Consequences

Uses and Gratifications Theory & Threats to Democracy

As today's youth become increasingly motivated to interact and share news for social gain, concerns of social media echo chambers and increased polarization have been on the rise. Studies have shown not only that those sharing news with the motivation of social utility are more likely to share misinformation, but also to create dangerous echo chambers among their

peers (Wei et. al, 2024). Echo chambers refer to the phenomenon of an artificial environment in which users are mainly exposed to information and opinions that align with their own, reinforcing existing beliefs and excluding opposing perspectives. When individuals operate within these chambers, misinformation spreads unchecked and skepticism toward alternative viewpoints hardens.

The consequences of this are significant for democracy. As echo chambers grow tighter, political polarization intensifies. Statistics have shown that increased social media dependency has a direct correlation to far-left or far-right views on the political spectrum (Mehlman-Brightwell et. al, 2024). As users become addicted to the feeling of social validation from peers, they are much more likely to only seek out and share information that will help them to attain that status. Instead of fostering civic dialogue, the pursuit of social gratifications through news sharing risks turning journalism into a tool that deepens divisions.

When young audiences interact with news primarily as a gateway towards peer validation, their political knowledge remains shallow, and their motivation to act on civic issues declines. Over time, this threatens the liveliness of democratic participation in the future by leaving an entire generation less informed and more divided.

Conclusion

In conclusion, Uses and Gratifications Theory helps us understand that the news consumption habits of America's youth are not fueled by information seeking behaviors, but instead by active choices to seek gratifications such as self-expression and peer approval. Unfortunately, these motivations have been shown to harbor the potential to lead Gen Z down a slippery slope of misinformation spread and increased polarization, risking the downfall of democratic cohesion in our nation. The research and discussion above proves that, if left unchecked, these dynamics will

erode journalism's ability to effectively inform citizens, foster meaningful conversations, and encourage civic action in today's youth.

As potential funders, it is with great hope that today's analysis has further underscored the need to find solutions that meet the needs of youth where they are at. Through finding innovative solutions to solving the issue of social media misinformation spread, we hope to engage youth through harnessing the power of social motivation while also protecting against misinformation. By investing in this project, you can help journalism rebuild its foundation in democracy and continue to shape future generations into the leaders of tomorrow.

References

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